

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN LIBERIA

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action shapes what happens to the land and forests of Liberia, and one clan's stand against a palm-oil company showed that a community, asserting its right to say no, can force even the highest office in the land to recognise that its customary land is its own. In Grand Bassa County, a British palm-oil company sought to expand its plantation onto some twenty thousand hectares of the Jogbahn Clan's customary land — the forests, farms, and wetlands the people rely on for their food and their living. The clan did not consent. Again and again, in meeting after meeting, they said no, and they invoked a right written into Liberia's own law: the right of a community to give or withhold its free, prior, and informed consent to what is done on its land. They gathered a petition signed by tens of thousands. They stood with Liberian and international organisations. And in a landmark meeting, the President of Liberia committed that the company could not expand onto the clan's land without the community's approval. The clan celebrated: their land, they said, was free. The details are worth setting down, because they show how such a fight is won. The company was a British firm, listed on a London market and backed by a large Malaysian palm-oil corporation; it had acquired earlier concessions covering tens of thousands of hectares, and it sought to extend its plantation onto the Jogbahn Clan's land in Grand Bassa County. The clan's answer rested on a right that was not merely felt but written: Liberia's community-rights law recognises a community's right to give or withhold its free, prior, and informed consent to activities on its customary land. So the clan did not only protest; it invoked that right, again and again, in more than twenty meetings with officials and legislators, and it refused to let the land be surveyed or cleared. Liberian and international organisations stood with it, a petition gathered tens of thousands of names, and the pressure rose until it reached the President herself, who met the communities and committed that the company could not expand onto their land without their approval. It was, as the organisations that supported the clan said, a significant victory for the recognition of customary land rights.

The Liberia story teaches two things about defending land here — including its honest limits, which this guide states plainly from the outset, for this was a landmark that had to be defended long after it was won. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever — the affected community, the documentation, the coalition, the right to consent, and the public pressure — pressed together. The second is distinctly Liberian, and it was won by a clan refusing to yield. **A community that owns its land by custom, and asserts its legal right to give or withhold its consent, can — with a broad coalition and public pressure — force the recognition of that right and keep even a foreign company off its land.** That power — the customary ownership of the land, the right of free, prior, and informed consent, the broad coalition, and the public pressure — is Liberia's distinctive lever, and this guide is built around it. What made the Jogbahn fight work as a model, and what a later community can copy, was that it turned a moral claim — this is our land — into a legal one: the right to consent. A community that merely objects to a project can be ignored; a community that invokes a right written into national law to give or withhold its consent is asserting something the government and the company must answer. The clan's power came from grounding its refusal in that right, documenting that its consent had been withheld, and then raising a pressure loud enough that the government had to recognise the right it was bound to honour. Own the land, withhold the consent the law lets you withhold, and raise the pressure until the right is recognised: that is the template — with the crucial caution, learned at Jogbahn, that the recognition of the right is where the fight turns, not where it ends.

But the same story carries honest warnings, and this guide will not hide them. The clan's victory was the **recognition of a right, not the end of the threat**: even after the President's commitment, the company kept surveying the land and pressing to clear it, and the clan had to go on resisting for years — so winning the right to say no is not the same as making the danger vanish. It is worth being especially candid about this, because it is the hardest and most important lesson of the Jogbahn story. A community that wins a government's recognition of its right may understandably believe the fight is over — and then find the company still surveying its land, still preparing to clear, still betting that the commitment will not be enforced and that the community's energy will fade. The recognition of a right is a powerful thing, but it is a shield the community must go on holding, not a wall that stands by itself; a commitment made under pressure can erode when the pressure lifts. A community should therefore treat the winning of the right not as the finish but as the moment its task changes — from winning the recognition to defending it — and plan, from the start, to keep its coalition, its documentation, and its watchfulness alive long after the first victory. The win leaned on a **political commitment** that had to be held to, not a final judgment. The fight carried **real danger** — community members were beaten and detained for it. And Jogbahn was **one clan's stand** in a country where much of the land had been handed to companies without the consent of the people who own it. This guide is written with both truths in view: the real, distinctive power of customary

ownership and the right to consent — and the ongoing struggle, the reliance on commitments, the danger, and the wider pattern that qualify it.

Most communities do not know HOW to make that power effective. They face a company on their land and assume "the concession is signed and the company is powerful and nothing can be done," and never assert their right to consent, never document their ownership, never build the coalition or the public pressure. They generate private fear without a public claim. The gap between a community that keeps its land and one that loses it is rarely will — the Jogbahn Clan showed that against beatings and pressure. It is method: knowing how to assert the right to consent, document the ownership, build the coalition, raise the pressure — and to keep defending the win.

This guide shows what actually works — inside the Liberian system as it is.

The Strategic Framework

Effective campaigns follow the same underlying pattern, whether the goal is to stop a plantation, a logging or mining concession, or another destructive project:

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STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION (find the concession, the right, and the leverage)
STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION        (build the evidence of ownership and harm)
STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION      (unite the community and assert the right to consent)
STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES      (the right to consent, the law, and the standards)
STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY        (raise a national and international cause)
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These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. Documentation feeds the assertion of the right and the public argument at once; the community unites and refuses consent; a petition or a government commitment is a moment that builds the coalition. The community that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others, is the one that wins — a plantation stopped, a right recognised, a land kept. The Jogbahn campaign did exactly this — it asserted the right to consent, documented the ownership, built a broad coalition, and raised a pressure that reached the President.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Liberia's give communities a distinctive set:

- **The customary ownership of the land.** Communities **own their customary land**, a right increasingly recognised in law, a strong foundation, as the Jogbahn Clan's ownership was. The strength of this lever has grown as Liberia's law has come to recognise, more fully than before, that communities own their customary land — a recognition advanced, in part, by struggles like the clan's. Where a community can establish that the land a company wants is its own customary land, held and used by it across generations, the company's concession is not a grant of empty or state land but an intrusion onto property that belongs to the community, and the burden shifts to those who would take it. This is why documenting the customary ownership — the history, the use, the boundaries, the graves and farms and forests that mark a people's long presence — matters so much: it establishes that the land is not the company's to take, but the community's to keep or to consent to part with.
- **The right to free, prior, and informed consent.** The **legal right to give or withhold consent** to projects on customary land is a powerful lever, as it was for the clan. This lever is distinctive because it converts a community's refusal from a mere wish into a legal entitlement. Free, prior, and informed consent means that a community must be asked before a project proceeds on its land, must be asked in good time and with full information, and — crucially — may say no. A project that proceeds without that consent is not merely unwelcome but in breach of the right, and that breach is something a government, a court, a standards body, and the public can all be asked to remedy. The Jogbahn Clan's power lay in insisting that its withheld consent was not a grievance to be soothed but a right to be honoured, and a community that grasps and asserts the right to consent holds a lever far stronger than objection alone.
- **The broad coalition.** A coalition of the **community, Liberian organisations, and international allies** brings reach and pressure, as it did for Jogbahn.
- **The public pressure.** A **petition and national and international attention** can force even the highest office to act, as they did.
- **The company's own commitments.** A company bound by **industry standards on consent and customary rights** can be held to them, as EPO was.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers deliver clean, final, safe wins. The Jogbahn victory was the **recognition of a right, not the end of the threat**; it leaned on a **commitment that had to be defended**; it carried **real danger**; and

it was **one clan's stand** in a wide pattern. This guide takes those limits seriously, names them plainly, and shows you how to use the real, distinctive tools Liberia offers — the customary ownership, the right to consent, the coalition, and the pressure — as the Jogbahn Clan used them, while facing the dangers and the long struggle honestly.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see. Before you spend a single week, map who actually decides your land's fate, at which level, and where along that path the concession — or the leverage — is weakest. And in Liberia, map the risks too, because this can be a dangerous fight.

The Levels of Decision

A Liberian land or concession project runs through several tracks at once, and each is a place to intervene.

The government and the presidency. The **government, the ministries, and the presidency** grant the concessions and can be moved by public pressure, the coalition, and the recognition of the community's rights, as the President committed to the Jogbahn Clan's right to consent. It is worth understanding why the presidency proved reachable in a fight of this kind, because it shapes the strategy. A government that grants concessions and courts investment will not lightly cross a company; what moved the President in the Jogbahn case was not the clan's objection alone but the pressure that objection had gathered — the tens of thousands of signatures, the national and international attention, the reputational cost of being seen to let a foreign company take a poor community's land against a right written in Liberia's own law. A campaign's task is to build exactly that kind of pressure, so that recognising the community's right becomes, for the government, the less costly course — as it became for the President who met the Jogbahn communities.

The communities and their customary ownership. Liberia's **communities own their customary land**, a right recognised in law, and their consent — or refusal — is a decisive lever, as the Jogbahn Clan's refusal was.

The companies. Foreign and domestic companies — a palm-oil company, a logger, a miner — drive the projects, and can be held to their commitments and exposed.

The right to consent, the law, and the standards. The **right to free, prior, and informed consent, the community-rights law, and the industry standards** are real constraints and levers, open to assertion and challenge.

The community and the coalition. The **community, the Liberian organisations, and the international allies** are the force that asserts the right, documents, unites, and raises the pressure — the force that kept a company off a clan's land.

The Journey of a Concession

A typical concession moves from a deal granted, through **survey and demarcation**, toward clearing and planting — with the **community, the government, and the public** able to assert the right to consent, refuse, and mobilise at any point. **Every one of those stages is a door you can put your foot in.** The distinctive Liberian doors are the **customary ownership**, the **right to consent**, the **broad coalition**, and the **public pressure**. Find out exactly where the concession stands, and, crucially, **whether the land is customary land the community owns, whether the community's consent was given or withheld**, and **whether the company can be held to the right to consent**, because those are often where a concession can be turned back.

Follow the Concession, the Ownership, and the Consent

Behind a project stand a proponent — a company, an investor — and the officials who granted the concession. Trace who decides, who profits, and — importantly in Liberia — **whether the land is customary land the community owns, whether the community gave or withheld its free, prior, and informed consent, whether the concession or the expansion is lawful and consented, and what the project does to the forests, farms, and livelihoods**. Two questions unlock most Liberian fights: **Is this our customary land, and did we consent?** and **Can we assert the right to consent, build the coalition, and raise the pressure?** The customary ownership and the right to consent are, together, the heart of most Liberian campaigns. The two reinforce one another in a way particular to these fights: the customary ownership establishes that the land is the community's, and the right to consent establishes that nothing may be done on it without the community's agreement. A community that asserts its ownership without invoking the right to consent may win recognition of its land yet find projects imposed on it; one that invokes the right to consent without establishing its ownership may be told the land is not really its to withhold. Joined together — this is our land, and we have not consented — they form a claim that is very hard to override, as the Jogbahn Clan's joined claim proved.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies and forces that can check the deciders, because they are levers too. The **government and the presidency**, movable by pressure; the **community-rights law and the courts**; the **industry standards bodies**, whose rules on consent a company may breach; the **Liberian organisations**; the **international organisations and networks**, whose reach is decisive; the **free press**; and the **public**, at home and abroad. In Liberia, the **customary ownership, the right to consent, the broad coalition, and the public pressure** are the most distinctive and decisive levers. Each is a separate front, and a concession that runs against a community's customary ownership, a withheld consent, a broad coalition, and a public pressure that reaches the presidency rarely proceeds untouched — as EPO's expansion onto Jombang land did not.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit months of effort, calibrate honestly. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how Liberian and comparable campaigns tend to go, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the land is **customary land the community owns**, whether the **consent was withheld** and the **right to consent can be asserted**, whether a **broad coalition** can be built, whether **public pressure** can be raised, and — gravely — whether the fight can be waged at a **bearable risk**. Where the ownership is clear and the consent withheld, Liberia's levers are real, as Jombang showed; but temper every figure with the honest knowledge that the win was the recognition of a right, not the end of the threat, that it had to be defended for years, and that it was dangerous.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost / Risk	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	5-10%	months	low	Basis for every other step
Asserting customary ownership	45-70%	months–years	low–moderate	The land shown to be the community's
The right to consent (FPIC)	45-70%	months–years	moderate / risk	The company blocked without consent
Broad coalition	45-70%	months–years	low–moderate	National and international pressure
Public pressure (petition, media)	45-70%	months	low–moderate	A government forced to recognise the right
Standards / legal challenge	35-60%	1-3 years	moderate	A company held to consent; a concession checked
Government / Presidential recognition	40-65%	months–years	moderate	The right to consent formally recognised
All steps (ownership clear, consent withheld, coalition broad)	45-70%	1-5 years	moderate / risk	Company kept off; right recognised and defended
All steps (ownership unclear, high risk, weak pressure)	25-50%	1-5 years	high risk	Delay; partial; the record

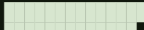
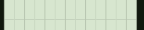
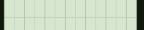
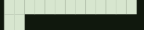
Key insight: every step together beats any single one, and Liberia's real strengths are distinctive — the **customary ownership**, the **right to consent**, the **broad coalition**, and the **public pressure**. Its constraints are specific and grave: the win may be the **recognition of a right, not the end of the threat**; it may need **defending for years**; and the fight carries **real risk**.

A note on cost and risk: asserting the ownership and the consent, building the coalition, and raising the pressure cost mainly time, unity, and the help of allies, and Liberia's communities, organisations, and international partners supply real support. But the gravest cost is risk: those who lead these fights have been beaten and detained, and a campaign must plan for the safety of its people as carefully as for its case.

Effectiveness Visualization

SUCCESS PROBABILITY (company kept off, right recognised, land kept)

OWNERSHIP CLEAR + CONSENT WITHHELD + COALITION BROAD + BEARABLE RISK:

All steps combined:		45-70%
Asserting ownership:		45-70%
The right to consent (FPIC):		45-70%
Coalition + public pressure:		45-70%
Single step:		5-70%

OWNERSHIP UNCLEAR / HIGH RISK / WEAK PRESSURE -- danger, weak coalition:

All steps combined:		25-50%
Documentation + int'l allies:		the levers that carry safest
Delay / the record:		more achievable than a full stop
Single step:		5-50%

How to read this honestly. The levers that most change outcomes in Liberia are **the customary ownership, the right to consent, the broad coalition, and the public pressure**, backed by the standards bodies and the courts. Jogbahn shows the ceiling: a clan asserted its ownership and its right to consent, built a coalition, and raised a pressure that reached the President, who recognised the right. But the honest floor is real too: the win was the recognition of a right, not the end of the threat; it had to be defended for years; and it was dangerous. Most Liberian fights sit between, and the honest lesson is that customary ownership, the right to consent, the coalition, and the pressure are powerful levers — decisive when the ownership is clear and the coalition broad, weaker when the space is most dangerous, where the realistic win is delay, a record, and a partial gain, and where the international allies carry the fight most safely. Read the table, then, as a diagnosis of your own position: a community that can show its clear customary ownership, has genuinely withheld its consent, and can build a broad coalition reaching to the international bodies is in the strong band and can aim to win the recognition of its right and keep the company off, as Jogbahn did; a community whose ownership is contested, or whose leaders face grave danger, is in the weaker band and should lean hardest on documentation and international allies, who can carry the fight most safely, while aiming realistically at delay and a record. Knowing which band you are in keeps a campaign both ambitious where it can be and, crucially here, safe where it must be.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **The customary ownership and the right to consent** — Liberia's most distinctive levers; the land the community owns, and its legal right to say no, as the Jogbahn Clan asserted them.
2. **The broad coalition** — the community, the Liberian organisations, and the international allies, standing together, as they stood for Jogbahn.
3. **The public pressure** — the petition and the national and international attention that reached the President.
4. **The government and Presidential recognition** — the formal recognition of the right to consent, the landmark that must then be defended.
5. **The standards and the courts** — the industry standards on consent and the community-rights law a company can be held to.

What Liberian Campaigns Actually Show

A few patterns recur. **Customary ownership is a foundation** — the land the community owns is a strong ground. **The right to consent obstructs** — a withheld consent, asserted, is a real and legal obstacle. **The coalition and the pressure reach the top** — a petition and international attention moved the President. **The company can be held to its commitments** — the standards on consent turned against it. **But the win is a right recognised, not a threat ended** — the company kept pushing, and the struggle went on. The through-line: **assert the customary ownership and the right to consent; build the broad coalition; raise the public pressure; win the recognition of the right — and then defend it — because in Liberia a community can force even the highest office to recognise that its land is its own.**

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective campaign begins by finding the exact concession that governs the threat — and the leverage the community holds, which in Liberia is often the customary ownership and the right to consent. Vague opposition goes nowhere; a fight aimed at "the expansion onto our customary land, to which we have not given our free, prior, and informed consent" is a campaign — the kind that won the Jogbahn Clan the recognition of its right. Answer five questions — and a sixth, about risk.

The Core Questions

1. **Is this our customary land, and can we show it?** This is the first Liberian question. Is the land **customary land**

the community owns, and can you show that ownership, as the Jogbahn Clan showed theirs, because the customary ownership is the foundation. This should be the very first thing a campaign establishes, because everything else is built on it. Where the land is clearly the community's own customary land, held and used across generations and recognised in law, the community stands on the strongest possible ground, and the company's concession is revealed as an intrusion onto property that is not its to take; where the ownership is contested or undocumented, the ground is weaker and must be shored up first. A community should therefore establish at the outset, through its own history and the community-rights law, exactly how it owns its land and how that ownership is recognised, so that it knows the strength of the foundation on which its right to consent stands.

2. Did we withhold our consent, and can we assert the right? Did the community **withhold its free, prior, and informed consent**, and can you **assert that right** — a right in Liberia's law and international law — as the clan asserted it against EPO. Assess this honestly at the outset, because the clarity and unity of the community's refusal is the load-bearing element of the whole strategy. The right to consent is powerful only if the community has genuinely withheld its consent — clearly, collectively, and on the record — rather than being divided, or having some members sign away what others refuse. A company that cannot win genuine consent will often try to manufacture it, negotiating quietly with a few, offering payments or jobs to some, playing families against one another. A campaign must reckon frankly with whether its community can hold together in a united refusal against these tactics, and make the sustaining of that unity — through the chiefs, honest shared information, and collective decision — a central task, for a united and documented refusal is the whole basis of the right to say no.

3. Can we build the coalition and raise the pressure? Can you build a **broad coalition** of the community, Liberian organisations, and international allies, and raise the **public pressure** — a petition, national and international attention — that reached the President for Jogbahn.

4. Can the company be held to its commitments? Is the company bound by **industry standards on consent and customary rights**, or by the law, that it can be **held to**, as EPO was bound by the palm-oil standards. Give this lever real attention, because a company's own commitments can become a powerful point of pressure independent of the national government. A palm-oil or other company seeking international markets and legitimacy often belongs to a sustainability scheme whose rules require respect for customary land rights and for free, prior, and informed consent — and a company shown to be taking a community's land without its consent is in breach of the very standard on which its market access and its reputation depend. A well-documented complaint to such a scheme does not merely embarrass the company; it threatens the certification and the buyers it needs, creating pressure that reaches beyond the reach of any national capture. A community should establish early what standards bind the company and hold it to them, as the Jogbahn campaign held EPO to the palm-oil scheme's consent requirements.

5. Who decides, who benefits, and who can be engaged? Which company, official, and investor are behind it, who profits; and which government bodies, standards bodies, organisations, allies, press, and public can be engaged.

6. What are the risks, and how will you manage them? In Liberia's sometimes dangerous space, what **risks** does the fight carry — to the community and its leaders, who have been beaten and detained — and how will you **manage them**: through numbers, non-violence, careful documentation, and the shield of international attention? This question is not optional here.

A Worked Example

Suppose a company seeks to expand onto a community's customary land, without the community's consent, promising development.

Working the questions: is it **our customary land**? Did we **withhold consent**, and can we **assert the right**? Can we build the **coalition and the pressure**? Can the company be **held to its commitments**? And what **risks**, managed how? The deciders are the company and the government, with the presidency, the standards bodies, and the public as the pressure points.

Within a season you have moved from "the concession is signed" to a target list: assert the customary ownership; withhold and assert the right to consent; build the coalition; raise the pressure; hold the company to its commitments; and manage the risks. That is a campaign, not a complaint — and it draws directly on how a clan kept a company off its land. Notice what the exercise did: it turned a sense that the concession was signed and the company too powerful into a set of concrete, winnable tasks — assert the ownership, withhold and assert the right to consent, build the coalition, raise the pressure, hold the company to its commitments, manage the risks — each tied to a specific lever that Liberia genuinely provides. That reframing, from resignation to a plan built on the customary ownership and the right to say no, is the difference the questions make, and the first two, whether the land is the community's and whether its consent was withheld, often decide how strong a hand the community holds.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on. A government, a company, a standards body, a journalist, and the public all move on evidence, not indignation — and in Liberia, the customary ownership, the withheld consent, and the harm are precisely what a campaign turns into pressure, so document them well and safely. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Ownership and the Consent

Get the evidence of what the land is and what the community decided. Document the community's **customary ownership** of the land — the history, the use, the boundaries, the recognition in Liberia's community-rights law — and, distinctively, the community's **withholding of consent**: the meetings, the refusals, the record that the community said no, as the Jogbahn Clan documented more than twenty meetings of refusal. Establish that the land is customary land the community owns and that its free, prior, and informed consent was not given — the two facts on which the whole case rests. These two facts deserve the most careful documentation of all, because they are the foundation on which every other lever is built. The ownership must be shown — through the community's history, its continuous use, its recognised boundaries, the farms and forests and sacred places that mark its long presence — so that no one can credibly claim the land was empty or the state's to give. And the withholding of consent must be recorded — the meetings, the dates, the clear refusals, the letters — so that no one can claim the community agreed or was properly consulted. The Jogbahn Clan's case was strong precisely because it could show both: that the land was demonstrably its own and that its refusal had been stated, clearly and repeatedly, over many documented meetings; a community should build the same unshakable record of ownership and refusal. It is worth adding that the record of refusal is not built in a day but accumulated over time, which is why beginning it early matters so much. Each meeting at which the community states its objection, each letter withholding consent, each occasion on which the company is reminded that it has no agreement, adds another dated entry to a record that, taken together, becomes impossible to deny. The Jogbahn Clan's more than twenty documented meetings of refusal were not a single dramatic act but a patient, cumulative record that left no room for the claim that consent had been given; a community should begin keeping that record from the very first approach, so that its refusal is documented long before any crisis, and cannot be waved away as an afterthought.

Layer 2: The Harm and the Conduct

Document the reality the paper understates, and put the **land and the people** at the centre. Record the **harm** — the forests, farms, and wetlands the community relies on that would be cleared, the livelihoods and food that would be lost — that the project would cause, as the Jogbahn Clan documented the loss of their forests and farms. And document the **company's conduct** — the survey and demarcation without consent, any intimidation, beatings, or detentions, any breach of its commitments, as the abuses against the clan were documented. Photograph and date it, safely. Record **testimony** from the community, and gather any **expert evidence**. This is the case that unites the community and moves the coalition.

Layer 3: The Ownership, the Consent, and the Breach

Finally, document the case. Is the land **customary land the community owns**? Was the **consent withheld**, and the right to consent breached? And does the project involve **harm and misconduct** — clearing without consent, intimidation, breach of standards? Each is a separate ground — for the government, the standards bodies, the courts, and the campaign — and together they make a case that is hard to wave away. This is the layer that most often decides Liberian fights, because here a project sold as development is revealed to take a community's own land without its consent, in breach of the law and the company's commitments — exactly the case that won the Jogbahn Clan the recognition of its right. The strength of assembling all three grounds together — the customary ownership, the withheld consent, and the harm and misconduct — is that they serve different fronts and reinforce one another: the ownership establishes that the land is the community's, the withheld consent that the law forbids proceeding without agreement, and the harm and misconduct that the company is both destroying what the community depends on and behaving unlawfully in doing so. A campaign that documents only one of the three may leave the company an escape — a claim to the land, a pretence of consent, a denial of harm — while a campaign that establishes all three, as the Jogbahn Clan did, leaves it with no honest ground to stand on and every audience a reason to act. Keep the documentation, and the documenters, as safe as you can: gather evidence in numbers, share it quickly with allies who can protect it, and hold copies where they cannot be seized. This care with the evidence is not mere caution but a strategic necessity in a space where those who resist have faced beatings and detention, and where a file lost or seized can undo months of work and expose those who gathered it. Keep copies in more than one place, and above all with trusted allies beyond the reach of local pressure, so that no raid, no confiscation,

and no intimidation can erase what the community has documented; share the key evidence early with the international organisations, whose possession of it both protects it and puts it beyond suppression. The Jogbahn campaign endured in part because its documentation lived in many hands, at home and abroad, and could neither be lost nor denied; a community should build the same resilience into how it holds its own evidence.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

This is the practical companion to Step 2: the specific records that decide Liberian cases, and where to obtain them. You will not need every item; you will need the few that establish the customary ownership, the withheld consent, and the harm.

The Concession, the Ownership, and the Paper Trail

- **The concession and the expansion** — the land granted, its size, its terms, and by which authority.
- **The record of customary ownership** — the community's history, use, boundaries, and legal recognition.
- **The consent record** — the meetings, the refusals, the documented withholding of consent.
- **The company's commitments** — its obligations under the standards and the law on consent.
- **The company and the beneficiaries** — who owns it, who profits, and its conduct.

How to Get Them

The concession terms are often matters of record, obtainable from the authorities and through the work of Liberian organisations; the customary ownership from the community's own knowledge and the community-rights law; the consent record from the community's own meetings, kept carefully; the company's commitments from the standards it has signed and the law. Lean on **allies**: Liberia's community-land and civil-society organisations, its lawyers, and the international organisations whose knowledge of consent, customary rights, and the standards is decisive, as they were for Jogbahn. Move promptly, and safely: documenting the ownership and the refusal early lets you assert the right and raise the pressure before the clearing advances, and gathering evidence in numbers and sharing it with allies protects both the evidence and the people.

The Ground Evidence

- **The customary ownership** — the community's land, its history, use, and boundaries.
- **The withheld consent** — the record that the community said no, again and again.
- **The harm** — the forests, farms, and wetlands, and the livelihoods, that would be lost.
- **The misconduct** — the survey without consent, the intimidation, the breaches.
- **Testimony and expertise** — from the community, and from the lawyers and experts.

Organise It So It Persuades — and Keep It Safe

Keep a **master timeline** of the concession, the ownership, the refusals, the harm, and every step of the fight — the spine of any case or campaign. Keep a **document index** so any fact can be sourced in seconds. And keep an **argument bank** (developed in a later section) that pairs each fact with what it proves, to whom. A well-ordered file is not bureaucracy; it is what lets a chief, a lawyer, an official, a standards body, and a journalist all see the same clear picture fast, and it guards against the campaign's own worst enemy, a claim that cannot be sourced when the company or the government pushes back. But in Liberia, keep the file — and the people — **safe**: hold copies with trusted allies, including abroad, so that the evidence cannot be seized or lost, and so that the documentation protects rather than exposes those who gathered it. In a fight where the customary ownership and the right to consent decide, the community whose better-documented, safely-held file — above all the clearest proof of its ownership and its refusal — reaches the government, the standards bodies, and the world is very often the one that keeps its land, as the Jogbahn Clan kept theirs.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION — HOW TO UNITE THE COMMUNITY AND ASSERT THE RIGHT TO CONSENT

Evidence does not win on its own. A united community that asserts its right to consent does — and in Liberia, Jogbahn proved that a clan, standing together and joined to its allies, can force the recognition of its right and keep a company off its land. A campaign's strength here is that unity and that assertion: the community united, the right asserted, and the

pressure raised.

Phase 1: The Core and the Chiefs

Start with a committed core rooted in the **community and its chiefs and elders** — because in Liberia the community's customary ownership and its collective refusal of consent are the decisive lever, as they were for Jogbahn. Assign roles — documentation, the legal and consent case, the coalition, media, and — vitally — safety. Agree on the goal — the company kept off, the right recognised, the land kept — and on what the community will and will not accept. And agree on the discipline of **non-violence and careful documentation**, both because it is right and because it protects the community from the pretexts used against those who resist. Draw on the community's bond to its land and its authority over it.

Phase 2: The Broad Coalition

Then widen deliberately, from the community to the world. Bring in the **whole community**, so that its refusal is united and cannot be split; the **Liberian community-land and civil-society organisations**, which bring the campaigning, the knowledge of the consent law, and the documentation, as they did for Jogbahn; sympathetic **lawyers**; the **international organisations and networks**, whose knowledge of consent, customary rights, and the standards, and whose reach and protective attention, are decisive, as they were for Jogbahn; sympathetic **legislators**; and the **wider public**, at home and abroad, whom a land-grab moves. Reach the **press**, at home and internationally, because a foreign company taking a community's land is a global story. The Jogbahn campaign drew its power from exactly this breadth — a united clan, Liberian organisations, and international allies — which is precisely the spread a winning Liberian campaign needs, and the international allies also help keep the local fighters safer. This protective role of the international allies deserves particular emphasis, because in a space where those who resist have been beaten and detained, it can matter as much as their documentation and reach. A local chief or organiser who stands alone against a company and its backers is dangerously exposed; the same person, known to and watched over by international organisations, journalists, and networks, is harder to silence, for retaliation against them carries an international cost. The attention that international allies brought to the Jogbahn fight not only pressured the company and the government but helped shield those who led the resistance, raising the price of any move against them. A community should therefore build these international relationships early and deliberately, both for the pressure they bring and for the measure of protection they extend to the people most at risk.

A worked coalition example. Facing an expansion onto its land, the community and its chiefs form the base and refuse consent; the Liberian organisations bring the campaign and the consent law; the international organisations bring the reach and the protective attention; the lawyers bring the legal case; sympathetic legislators press within the government; and the press carries it to the nation and the world. No single group could carry it; together they cover the land, the right, the law, and the pressure — the model Jogbahn built.

Phase 3: Sustaining It — and Staying Safe

Campaigns die of burnout, or are broken by fear — and a Liberian fight can run for years, in a dangerous space, even after a first victory. Meet on a rhythm, safely. Give people concrete tasks. Mark small wins — the ownership documented, the petition swelling, a government commitment, a company held to its standards, a wave of coverage. Keep the community united and the chiefs engaged, and guard against the **division, the intimidation, and the fear** — the offers to split the community, the beatings and threats, the pressure to give up — that will be used against you. Above all, protect your people: spread leadership so no one person is the whole campaign, keep the international attention on those most at risk, and respond to intimidation by documenting it and raising it loudly, because a movement that stands together, stays non-violent, and keeps the world watching is both harder to break and safer, as the international attention helped shield the Jogbahn Clan.

Phase 4: Asserting the Right and Defending the Win

Here is Liberia's distinctive strength, on two levels. First, **assert the right to consent**: have the community, together, **withhold its consent and assert its legal right** to give or withhold it, refusing to let the land be surveyed or cleared, and pressing the government to **recognise that right**, as the Jogbahn Clan pressed until the President recognised it — always non-violently and well-documented. Second, **defend the win**: because, distinctively and honestly, a recognition of the right is not the end — the company may keep pushing, as EPO did after the President's commitment — so hold the government to its recognition, keep the coalition and the pressure alive, and go on defending the land. Keep it **united, non-violent, well-documented, safe, and enduring**, because in Liberia it is the community that asserts its right to consent and then defends the recognition of that right that keeps its land — as the Jogbahn Clan did.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES — THE RIGHT TO CONSENT,

THE LAW, AND THE STANDARDS

Liberia's law on customary land and consent, its courts, the industry standards a company may be bound by, and the international frameworks are a real and distinctive toolkit. You do not need a courtroom victory to win: a right to consent recognised, a government commitment, a standard enforced, a delay while you build the pressure, or a company that pulls back can each be a real victory — and the lasting work is defending the recognition of the right. Engage lawyers and allies early — but understand the tools.

The Right to Free, Prior, and Informed Consent

The first and most distinctive lever is the **right to free, prior, and informed consent**. Liberia's **Community Rights Law** gives communities the **right to give or withhold their consent** to activities on their customary land — a right reinforced by international human-rights law — and a project that proceeds **without that consent** breaches it, as EPO's expansion onto Jogbahn land did. Assert the right, document the withholding of consent, and demand that the government and the company honour it; this is the bedrock of a Liberian land defence.

The Customary Land Law

The second lever is the **customary land law**. Liberia's law increasingly **recognises communities' ownership of their customary land** — a recognition strengthened by the land-rights reform that followed struggles like Jogbahn's — and a concession or expansion that runs against that ownership can be challenged on that ground. Assert the community's ownership; it is both a legal ground and the foundation of the right to consent.

The Standards and the International Frameworks

The third lever, distinctive to a company seeking markets or legitimacy, is the **standards and the international frameworks**. A palm-oil or other company may be bound by an **industry sustainability standard** requiring respect for customary rights and free, prior, and informed consent — and a company shown to breach that standard can be complained against and can lose the certification and legitimacy it needs, as EPO was bound by the palm-oil standard's consent requirements. Hold the company to the standards it has signed; a complaint there is real pressure.

Where to Turn and With Whom

The right to consent and the customary ownership go through the **government, the courts, and the pressure**; the standards through the **standards bodies**. Get help early: Liberia's community-land and civil-society organisations, its lawyers, and the international organisations know the consent law, the customary land law, and the standards, as they knew them for Jogbahn — and can act from abroad where the space at home is most constrained. Help engaged early is worth far more than help sought after, and in Liberia the strongest strategy marries the **right to consent and the customary ownership** to the **coalition and the public pressure**, so that a company taking a community's land without its consent is confronted with the community's legal right, the government's recognition, the standards it has breached, and a pressure it cannot ignore — as EPO was at Jogbahn.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

You have a file of evidence. Now you must turn it into arguments — because the same fact persuades the government, a standards body, a journalist, and the public in different ways. Learning to translate your evidence for each audience is what lets a community reach every lever at once.

One Fact, Many Arguments

Take a single documented fact — say, that a company is surveying a community's customary land to clear it for a plantation, though the community has repeatedly withheld its free, prior, and informed consent. That one fact becomes:

- **A right-to-consent argument:** the community has withheld its consent, and the law gives it that right — the case that stops the expansion.
- **An ownership argument:** this is the community's own customary land — the case for the government and the courts.
- **A standards argument:** the company breaches the consent and customary-rights standards it has signed — the case before the standards bodies.

- **A human argument:** a community's forests, farms, and food are being taken without its consent — the case that unites the coalition and moves the public.
- **A conduct argument:** the company surveys without consent and intimidates the people — the case that shames it and exposes its breach.

Same fact, five arguments, five audiences. Go through your strongest facts and, for each, ask what it proves to each audience. That table is your campaign's argument bank — and in Liberia the arguments that most often decide things are the **right-to-consent** one, because it is the community's legal shield, and the **human** one, because a community's land taken without its consent moves the public and the government. Keep the arguments anchored to the same documented facts, so a claim made to a reporter can be backed in the record and a claim made to a standards body can be proven against its rules; consistency across audiences is itself persuasive.

Match the Argument to the Audience

The government and the presidency respond to the public pressure, the community's legal right to consent, the international attention, and the political cost of a land-grab.

The courts want the customary ownership and the breach of the right to consent framed against the community-rights law.

The standards bodies want the breach of the consent and customary-rights standards, proven precisely against the standard.

Journalists need a specific, vivid story with a hook: a foreign company taking a community's own land without its consent, and beating those who resist.

The public and the international allies need the argument clear and moral: a community's land, its food, its forests — taken without its consent.

The community needs to see the right is real and the fight winnable, so it stands united and refuses consent, as the clan stood.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY — HOW COVERAGE SHIFTS OUTCOMES

Media is not vanity; it is a lever — and in Liberia, where a company taking a community's land without its consent is a story that shames it and moves a government, coverage that carries the right to consent and the injustice is among the most powerful levers of all, and — importantly — international attention also helps protect those at risk. Coverage pressures the government, shames the company, and shields the community. The Jogbahn campaign reached the President in large part by raising a public storm — a petition of tens of thousands and national and international attention — that a government could not ignore.

Build the Story

Reporters and the public need specifics, and here they need the consent, the ownership, and the injustice. "A project is controversial" is not a story; "a foreign company is taking a community's own land, which it owns, without the consent the law requires, and beating those who resist" is — the kind of story that reached the President for Jogbahn. Lead with your strongest verified facts — the customary ownership, the withheld consent, the misconduct — and offer a human voice: a chief, an elder, a farmer. In Liberia, and to the world, the story of a community's land taken without its consent is one that draws real attention.

Reach the Right Outlets

Work outward in rings. **Local and community voices** first, safely. Then the **national outlets** — because national opinion and the pressure it brings reached the President. Then, distinctively and importantly, the **international ring** — the international press, the land-rights and forest networks, and the audiences and investors in the company's home market — because a company seeking legitimacy and markets is **vulnerable to its international standing**, and international attention is both a strong pressure and a shield for those at risk, as it was for Jogbahn. Feed each ring what it needs, and let coverage in one pull in the next. The **national and international rings are both decisive** here, for pressure and for protection.

Sustain It, and Keep It True and Safe

A single article changes little; a drumbeat changes decisions — and a Liberian fight runs for years, even after a first victory. Plan a sequence — the ownership, the withheld consent, the petition, the government commitment, the company's defiance — so there is always a next hook, and build your own clear record so the story reaches the nation and the world. Keep messaging disciplined, accurate, and rigorous; the company and the government will seize on any exaggeration, and a credible, consent-and-ownership-centred campaign is what shames a company and moves a government. And keep it **safe**: let the international allies carry what is dangerous to say at home. Verified, specific, consent-and-ownership-centred, internationally aimed, and safe — that is the coverage that shifts outcomes here, and that helped win the recognition of a clan's right.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Written communications are how you request, object, create a record, and reach the bodies that can act — the government, the company, the standards bodies, the courts, and the press. Each does double duty: it asks for something and it documents that you asked. Keep copies of everything, with trusted allies, and send important items so that receipt is provable. Below are adaptable templates for the situations you will meet most often. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the customary ownership, the withheld consent, and the harm — and mind your safety.

8A. Request for Information

To: the relevant authority **Subject:** Request for information on [concession / expansion]

We, [community/organisation], request the **concession and expansion documents, the terms, and the maps** for [project] affecting our customary land. This is our land, and we are entitled to know what is planned on it. Please provide the documents.

8B. Withholding Consent (from the Community and Chiefs)

To: the company, copied to the government **Subject:** [Community/clan] withholds its consent to [project] on our customary land

We, the chiefs and people of [community/clan], **withhold our free, prior, and informed consent** to [project] on our customary land. This land is ours; we rely on its forests, farms, and wetlands; and we have not agreed to cede it or to its survey or clearing. Under Liberia's Community Rights Law and international law, we have the **right to say no**, and we do. We call on you to **cease all survey and clearing** on our land.

8C. Petition to the Government

To: the government / the President **Subject:** Petition to protect [community]'s customary land from [project]

We, the undersigned — [number] people of Liberia and beyond — call on the government to **recognise and protect [community]'s right to give or withhold its consent** to [project] on its customary land, and to ensure that no expansion, survey, or clearing proceeds **without the community's consent**. [Signatures.]

8D. Complaint to a Standards Body

To: the standards body of [company] **Subject:** Complaint regarding [project] — breach of consent and customary-rights standards

We, [community/organisation], submit that [company]'s [project] **breaches your standards** on free, prior, and informed consent and customary rights: it proceeds on our customary land **without our consent**. We request that you **review the breach** and require the company to **respect our right to consent**, and we attach the evidence.

8E. Instructing a Lawyer / Organisation

To: a community-land lawyer / land-rights organisation **Subject:** [Project] — the ownership, the consent, and the challenge

We are opposing [project] on our customary land. We attach the concession documents, our record of ownership and of

withheld consent, and our evidence, and seek advice on **the right to consent, the customary land law, and the standards complaint** — and on **the safety** of those involved. Please advise on the strongest routes.

8F. Appeal to International Allies

To: an international land-rights / forest organisation **Subject:** Help us defend our customary land from [project]

We write regarding [project], which would take our customary land — our forests, farms, and food — without our consent. As the international organisations stood with the Jogbahn Clan, we ask for your **documentation, your reach, your knowledge of the standards, and your protective attention**. We attach our case and can host your researchers, safely.

8G. Email to a Reporter

To: [journalist] **Subject:** Story tip: [specific finding] — [our land / the company / the project]

I follow your coverage of [beat]. We have a story of international interest, with a clear hook: [documents] show [finding — e.g. "a foreign company is taking a community's own land without its consent, and intimidating those who resist"]. It echoes the Jogbahn Clan. I can share the file and connect you with a chief and a lawyer. Could we talk this week?

8H. Public Statement

To: the public and the authorities **Subject:** [Community/organisation] will defend our customary land

We, [community/organisation], oppose [project], which would take our **customary land** — our forests, farms, and food — **without our consent**. As the Jogbahn Clan asserted its right to say no and won the recognition of that right, we will document our ownership, withhold and assert our right to consent, build our coalition, raise the pressure, and defend our land. We will not relent.

Using the Templates Well

Send important communications so that receipt is provable, keep copies with trusted allies, and log every one in your timeline — the record of a withheld consent, a petition, or a complaint is itself evidence, and exactly what the government, the standards bodies, and the world will heed. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the customary ownership, the withheld consent, and the harm; attach your evidence; route them, where you can, through the community, the organisations, the international allies, your lawyers, and the press; and mind your safety. The reply, or the result, becomes part of your record, and in Liberia that record feeds the levers that matter most: the customary ownership, the right to consent, the broad coalition, and the public pressure that won — and then defended — a clan's right.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Not everyone can run a years-long campaign. With a few hours a week you can still do real work to defend your land — safely. In rough order of impact for the effort:

- 1. Document the ownership and the refusal.** Establish that the land is yours and that you withheld consent (Step 2, 8A).
- 2. Withhold consent, formally.** Have the community and chiefs put the withholding of consent on the record (8B).
- 3. Petition the government.** Start a petition for the recognition of your right to consent (8C).
- 4. Reach the organisations and lawyers.** Connect with community-land organisations and lawyers (8E, 8F).
- 5. Complain to the standards bodies.** Where the company is bound by standards, complain of the breach (8D).
- 6. Raise the pressure in the press.** Take the injustice to the national and international press (Step 5, 8G).
- 7. Mind your safety, and defend the win.** Act in numbers, non-violently, keep the world watching — and keep defending any recognition you win.

Do only the first three and you will have documented your ownership, withheld consent, and petitioned the government —

the foundation of a Liberian defence. Then come back and read the rest. Even the shortest version has a spine: document the ownership, withhold consent, petition — and defend what you win.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Liberia's system is tilted in specific and serious ways you must understand, so you neither waste effort nor walk into danger unprepared.

Where the Tilt Shows

The tilt here is real and grave. **Powerful companies and investors**, and a government that champions their concessions as development in a poor country, carry great weight, and much of the land has been handed to companies without the consent of the people who own it. The **civic space can be dangerous**: those who resist have been **beaten and detained**, as the Jogbahn people were. A recognition of a right can be **defied**: even after the President's commitment, the company kept pushing, so a win must be defended. And a determined company can **wear a community down** or divide it. Where these tilts bite, a campaign that assumes a concession cannot be challenged, or that a government commitment ends the threat, will be disappointed — and may be endangered — which is precisely why the distinctive strategy leans on the right to consent, the broad coalition, the public pressure, and the protection that international allies bring, and on defending the win long after it is first won.

What Still Works — And Some Is Strong

The decisive point is that even against this grave tilt, real levers remain — and some are strong.

The customary ownership still holds. Communities own their customary land, a right increasingly recognised in law.

The right to consent still obstructs. A withheld consent, asserted under the law, is a real and legal obstacle.

The coalition and the pressure still reach the top. A petition and international attention pressured the President himself.

The standards still constrain. A company seeking markets can be held to its consent and customary-rights commitments.

The international alliance still carries — and protects. International documentation, reach, and attention pressure the company and help shield those at risk.

The Honest Frame

So the honest frame for Liberia is realistic, hopeful, and clear-eyed about danger and about the long haul: the space can be dangerous and a win must be defended, but the customary ownership, the right to consent, the coalition, and the pressure give a community real, and sometimes strong, levers — especially where the international ring carries the pressure and the protection. So diagnose your fight honestly: assert the **customary ownership** and the **right to consent**; build the **broad coalition**; raise the **public pressure**; **manage the risks**; and **defend the win**. Do not assume a concession cannot be challenged, or that a commitment ends the threat; the Jogbahn Clan won the recognition of its right, and even so, at real cost, had to go on defending its land.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

Liberia has real and documented concerns about corruption and the capture of land decisions by powerful interests, so this section matters. When a concession is driven not by the public interest but by the connected, or by a company's weight over the institutions, your strategy includes exposing that — carefully.

How to Tell

Look for the signatures of capture. Land **handed to a company without the consent of the people who own it**; a **concession granted against the law and the community-rights law**; **assessments or consent processes**

skipped or faked; close ties between the company, the officials, and the connected; and **benefits to the connected** while the community loses its land. Trace the concession and the interests: who granted it, who profits, whether the community's ownership and consent were bypassed for the connected. In Liberia, where much of the land has been handed to companies without consent, a concession over a community's land is worth examining for the influence behind it.

Who Can Be Captured — and Who Is Harder

Be clear-eyed about where capture reaches. **Parts of the government, the land administration, and the local authorities** can be captured or pressured by powerful interests. But some forces are far harder to capture, and they are your targets: the **international standards bodies**, beyond national capture; the **international press and organisations**; the **community and its chiefs**, rooted in the land; the **consumers and investors** in the company's markets; and, where they can act, the **courts** and a **President** movable by public pressure. Distinctively, the international dimension — the standards, the markets, the press — and the community's own united refusal are what most escape national capture; your task is to document the capture, assert the right to consent, and bring the exposure to the international bodies and the world.

What to Do

Do not assume a captured concession cannot be undone. Instead, **document the capture precisely** — how the land was handed over, the consent bypassed, who profits — and take it to the forces that can act: the **international standards bodies**; the **international press and organisations**; the **courts and a President** movable by pressure; and the **consumers and the public**. Pair the exposure with the assertion of the right to consent and the customary ownership, so the impropriety and the taking of the land arrive together. In Liberia, exposing how a community's land was handed to a company without its consent, and bringing that to the world and to a President under pressure, is often the way to win the recognition of the right — as the exposure and the pressure won it for the Jogbahn Clan. Do all of this with care for your safety, for exposing the powerful is where the risk is greatest.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The five steps win when they run together. Here is how they fit across the life of a fight — which in Liberia turns on the customary ownership, the right to consent, and the public pressure, all managed with care for safety and for the long haul.

Early (Months 0-8): The Ownership, the Consent, and the Coalition

Pin down the concession and the deciding bodies (Step 1); document the **customary ownership** and the **withheld consent** (Step 2). Unite the **community** and build the **coalition** with the Liberian organisations and international allies (Step 3). Move at once on what is decisive: **request the information** (8A); **withhold consent** formally (8B); **petition the government** (8C); reach **lawyers and international allies** early (8E, 8F); and begin the **standards complaint** (8D). And put **safety** in place from the start. This phase lays the foundation, and in Liberia the ownership, the withheld consent, and the coalition established here are what win.

Middle (Months 6-48+): Assert, Pressure, and Win the Recognition

Sustain the community and the coalition (Step 3). Turn your evidence into arguments for each audience (Turning Evidence). Assert the **right to consent** and pursue the **standards and legal** challenges (Step 4). Build the media drumbeat, aimed at the government and the company's international standing (Step 5), and press for the **government's recognition** of the right. Each front feeds the others. Do the time-critical things first — asserting the ownership and consent before the clearing advances — because those chances are most powerful early, and protect your people throughout.

Later (Months 12-many): The Recognition — and Its Defence

Pursue the decisive outcome — the **right to consent recognised, the company kept off the land** — and then, distinctively and crucially, **defend it**, because, as Jogbahn showed, the company may keep pushing after the recognition, so the win must be held. Judge success honestly. Sometimes it is a right recognised and a company kept off. Sometimes it is a recognition that must be defended for years, or a partial gain to be secured. Both, where they keep the land, are victories worth the fight — and worth the vigilance.

The Shape of a Campaign

MONTHS 0-8 Document ownership + withheld consent | Build the coalition | Withhold consent + petition | Put safety in place
MONTHS 6-48+ Assert the right to consent | Standards + legal challenge | Public pressure | Win the recognition
MONTHS 12-many Right recognised / company kept off | Defend the win, for the company may keep pushing

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Liberia gives communities a genuinely powerful — and distinctive — set of tools, and the honest measure of this guide is how squarely it faces both their strength and their limits, including the danger and the long struggle.

The strengths are real and distinctive. The **customary ownership** of the land — a right increasingly recognised in law — is a strong foundation. The **right to free, prior, and informed consent** — the legal right to give or withhold consent to what is done on that land — is a powerful lever, a right to say no. The **broad coalition** — the community, the Liberian organisations, and the international allies — brings the reach, the pressure, and the protection. And the **public pressure** — a petition, national and international attention — can reach even the highest office. These are the tools that let the Jogbahn Clan force the President to recognise that its land was its own.

The limits are just as real, and this guide names them. The Jogbahn victory was the **recognition of a right, not the end of the threat** — the company kept pushing, and the struggle went on for years. It leaned on a **commitment that had to be defended**. It carried **real danger** — the people were beaten and detained. And it was **one clan's stand** in a country where much of the land had been handed to companies without consent. No guide should pretend these away; in Liberia, the art is to assert the ownership and the right to consent, build the coalition, raise the pressure, win the recognition — and then defend it — all with unflinching care for the safety of your people.

So the realistic promise is this: **assert the customary ownership and the right to consent; build the broad coalition; raise the public pressure; manage the risks; win the recognition of the right — and defend it — running all of it together**. Do that, and where the ownership is clear and the coalition broad, you can force the recognition of your right and keep even a foreign company off your land, as the Jogbahn Clan did; where the space is most dangerous, you can still win delay, a record, and a partial gain, with the international allies carrying the fight most safely. Do it as the Jogbahn Clan did — a community that owned its land, asserted its right to say no, and would not yield.

A last word on the right and its defence. Liberia's lesson is that a community that owns its land by custom, and asserts its legal right to give or withhold its consent, can force even the highest office to recognise that its land is its own — but that the recognition of a right is not the end of the threat, that the win may have to be defended for years, and that the fight may be dangerous. The powerful count on your believing the concession is signed and the land as good as lost, or on frightening you into silence, or on outlasting you after a first defeat. Their advantage is their money, their ties to the connected, the fear they can spread, and their patience. Yours is the customary ownership, the right to say no, the broad coalition, the public pressure, the international allies, and the proven fact that the Jogbahn Clan forced the recognition of its right. Play to that — and guard your people, and defend your win. Keep the documented record safe with your allies, keep the community united and non-violent, assert the right to consent, raise the pressure, hold the government to its recognition, and treat every refusal recorded, every signature gathered, every commitment won, and every acre kept as a stone in a wall that even a foreign company cannot climb.

The tools are here, and Liberia itself proved them: the Jogbahn Clan, facing a British company that wanted twenty thousand hectares of their customary land, refused their consent, documented their ownership, gathered tens of thousands of signatures, stood with allies at home and abroad, and forced the President of Liberia to recognise their right to say no — and then went on defending that right against a company that would not easily let go. What decides the outcome, in the end, is the customary ownership, the right to consent, the breadth of the coalition, the force of the public pressure, and the resolve to defend the win — and those a determined community can summon, with care for its safety. Begin today, begin with the ownership and the right to say no and the coalition, and build from there. Communities before you have forced the recognition of their right and kept their land — a company held off, a right recognised, a clan's land kept free. What the Jogbahn Clan won can be won again. So can yours.